

54% sent off to coaching classes after school



63% become breathless when climbing stairs



16% crave for love and affection from extended family

30% have poor muscle strength and shape



36% of the children get little solace from home

excess weight (18 per cent) and obesity (6 per cent) among them. "In the past two decades, adolescent weight has gone up by 5-15 kg," says Tandon, professor at the department of endocrinology and metabolism, AIIMS. "The soaring symptoms of metabolic dysfunction among them indicate early onset of conditions like diabetes, hypertension, heart diseases and polycystic ovarian syndrome." It's not just the rich kids in the capital. An ongoing Fortis Hospital study, that also covers cities beyond Delhi (Agra, Jaipur, Allahabad and Pune), finds abdominal fat, insulin resistance and hypertension in one among four schoolchildren—indicating a likely explosion of lifestyle diseases when they reach the 20s.

Pritish Daudkhane is all of 11. But his schedules are more demanding and days more packed than his parents. And his mother, Parumita, who runs

coaching classes in Navi Mumbai, is worried sick. Pritish looks and acts drained and exhausted at the end of each day. The student of Vasant Vihar High School wakes up every morning at 5.30 to catch his school bus, gets back by 2 p.m., watches television or plays computer games till it's time to do homework or leave for coaching classes. "He wakes up too early," claims his mother. "With the pressure of homework and coaching classes, he hardly has the physical stamina or enthusiasm to do anything else." Pritish got into this mode ever since he entered high school. "I have never consulted a counsellor because every child seems to be leading this sort of a life. But it upsets me," she says.

The survey rings alarm bells over the physical fitness of children. The World Health Organization guidelines recommend 60 minutes of moderate intensity physical activity each day, with activities to improve bone health, muscle strength and flexibility at least twice a week. But India's couch potato kids (over 30 per cent) prefer to spend 4-6 hours a day in front of the TV. Over 37 per cent are physically unfit; 30 per cent don't have the time to play; 30 per cent have poor muscle strength and shape and 43 per cent have poor joint mobility. "Children are turning out to be sitting ducks for bone disorders later in life," says Dr Ambrish Mithal, endocrinologist with Apollo Indraprastha Hospital in Delhi. A new study by AIIMS and the Institute of Nuclear Medicine and Allied Sciences in Delhi found rampant vitamin D deficiency (essential for strong bones) in nearly 90 per cent schoolchildren in the city in 2006.

Not a pretty picture? Gear up for some more gory statistics: 65 per cent

30% do not have the time to play outdoor games

